boss:

‘Where the hell are you?’

‘Eh?’

‘Where the hell are you?’

‘I’m in my car.’

‘Don’t lie to me. You’re in Barcelona, aren’t you?’

I nearly laughed out loud:

‘I’m in my car. I’m just driving out of the Trafford Center.’

The manager wasn’t having any of it:

‘My mate has seen you at Barcelona airport.’

What could I say? I described the parking lot at the Trafford Center, told him which shops I’d been in. There was a long silence:

‘OK. Goodbye.’

I found out later that, five minutes before he rang me, the boss had rung Gary to find out where I was and tell him what he’d heard. Because of what had been talked about at the meeting earlier that same morning, Gary had put the phone down and just thought to himself:

‘Dave, after all that’s gone on, please don’t be in Spain.’

It was such a weird turn in the tale. I couldn’t believe we’d had the conversation. The boss knows people all over Manchester, knows everything that’s going on with the players. People must tell him things they say they’ve seen or heard all the time: someone had just told him I’d gotten off a plane in Barcelona. The problem with those stories is that they must really get under the boss’s skin, whether they’re true or not, which doesn’t help me or whoever else the stories are about. I don’t think I could have lived my life better from a professional point of view: looking after myself, being careful about things like drinking and staying out late. When I went down to London to see family and friends, I never let the traveling get in the way of my job. For a game on a Saturday, Wednesday evening would be the absolute latest I’d ever be driving back to Manchester. The rumors, though, which had led to